fact that both of us are unconventional mothers." The meeting made the actor doubly determined to deliver with her performance. Sen's command over the character is visible throughout the six episodes. Even when the screenplay or the direction dips, Sen's expressive emotional language holds it together.

Sen's commitment to the role spilled offscreen too. Before directing her in *Taali*, Jadhav admits that he harboured misconceptions about Sen's cachet as a Bollywood star. He came out of the show bowled over by her professionalism. "Usually, actors take about four or five takes to get a scene right, because every take acts as a rehearsal for them. But Sushmita Sen is one of the rare actors I have worked with who comes to a set fully prepared. She only needs one take. In fact, 90 per cent of the scenes you see of her in the show are actually from her first take."

Given that *Taali* chronicles the full extent of Sawant's life, right from her childhood and her surgery to motherhood and the legal battle, the actor sees her performance as a tribute to Sawant's strength. To her, the fact that Sawant entrusted her with the honour of showcasing her journey onscreen is the icing on the cake.

Irrespective of the scope of future projects, the 47-year-old is certain about where she stands as an actor. "I want to represent a story that has the power to move you from the core and stir a wave of change. That is what I look for in everything I do." ■

Poulomi Das

ENTERTAINMENT

BREAKING BARRIERS

MEET TRANS DOCTOR-TURNED-ACTOR **TRINETRA HALDAR GUMMARAJU**, WHO PLAYS THE ROLE OF MEHER CHAUDHRY IN THE SECOND SEASON OF *MADE IN HEAVEN*



Gummaraju auditioned for Made in Heaven S2 in December 2020 while still interning at a hospital in Karnataka

SUNNY CHOTHANI

Ever since its release on Amazon Prime, *Made in Heaven* S2 has courted controversy for several reasons—from misrepresentation of facts to breach of faith. However, the show created by filmmakers Zoya Akhtar and Reema Kagti has also received appreciation for showcasing the reality of big fat Indian weddings beyond their glamour and opulence. The second instalment also has a new addition—trans doctor, content creator and now actor, Trinetra Haldar Gummaraju.

On being asked how it feels to play herself on screen, the debutante has a quick rebuttal. "We don't tell heroes they play themselves just because they play men. Meher is calm, introverted and reserved. Her politics is put across with a very understated dignity," says Gummaraju. "In real life, I am far more vocal about my identity. Meher isn't necessarily known to everyone as trans, while I am."

While Bollywood has previously attempted making queer-focused films, the treatment has been far from appropriate. Gummaraju calls her character a big win on the representation front, since trans people never get to play any role. "Cis actors get the opportunity to play a very diverse range of roles and often get brownie points for essaying trans characters," she reiterates.

Calling it a "dream come true", Gummaraju auditioned for *Made in Heaven* S2 in December 2020 while still interning at a hospital in Karnataka. It was her popularity on Instagram that led to her discovery by the *Made in Heaven* team. "When the audition worked out, it was reassuring that I had something unique to offer. I was essentially a sleepless intern and had nothing to lose," she says.

The transition to acting happened fairly abruptly, but acting coach Puja Sarup played a huge role in giving Gummaraju the basic tools to play the character. "The responsibility to correctly represent a community can be tough. I placed my trust entirely in the writing of this character as human first and trans later," says Gummaraju.

The show portrays Meher's trials and tribulations, particularly while navigating romantic relationships. With more conversation around sexuality and gender today, is there receptivity towards dating a trans woman? "Understanding of trans identity is restricted largely to upper middle class and urban circles, so penetrating through all tiers of society will take time. This is where entertainment becomes a powerful tool to start conversations," believes Gummaraju. In her personal experience, people have become more aware and accepting, but there's a long way to go.

With Meher's character being applauded by the masses, what's next on the cards? "A single great role doesn't necessarily mean an entire career. One has to keep at it and continue auditioning, and hope that wonderful characters are written," concludes Gummaraju. ■

Geetika Sachdev